Good Academic Writing

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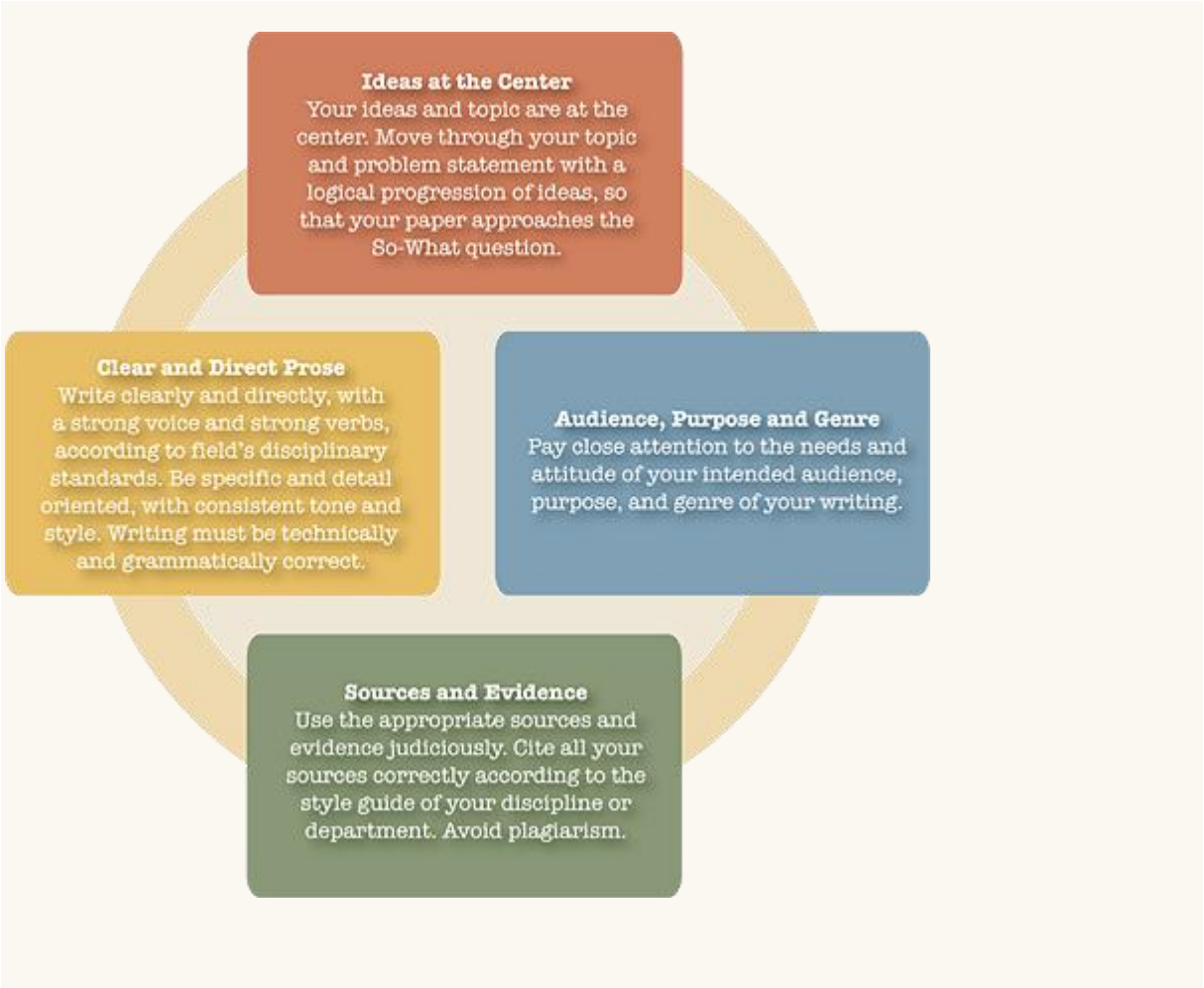
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X. The Writing Process: From Ideas to Clear Writing and Back Again

Mar 28, 2011 Caroline Eisner

Unlike many subjects, writing is a recursive act. It goes on and on. When you are almost finished, you polish your prose, correct your grammar, check for any mechanical errors, and the next morning, as you are about to turn it in, you look at it one more time, and say to yourself, "Oh, I wish I had remembered to include that source, or paraphrased that quotation, oh, and where's that comma?" In other words, writing is one big back and forth, until you decide it is polished enough.

The graphic below summarizes the elements of good academic writing that have been the subject of this blog series: starting with your own good ideas; getting clear on the audience, purpose, and genre of the writing; using sources judiciously; and writing clear and direct prose. The writing process is recursive. Revisions are essential to refine your ideas and develop your argument. As you learn the rules of academic writing, you will join the ranks of scholars and enter the conversation of ideas.



IX. Use a Consistent Tone and Style, and Make Sure Your Writing Is Mechanically Competent

Mar 21, 2011 Caroline Eisner

This blog continues the discussion from the previous week by asking you to match the tone and style of your discipline and field as you write for an advanced academic audience. One of the best ways to understand the tone and style of your discipline is to read articles from a top journal in your discipline. You might even ask your advisor to recommend articles to read that are well written and prove good points. Again, this work needs to happen after you have finished the real and hard work of formulating your ideas into a logical and meaningful argument.

The tone and style of academic writing might at first seem intimidating. Readers want their writers to write clearly and intelligently on matters that they care about. What professors do not want is imitation scholarship—that is, any kind of high language such as using the word, "heretofore," or steeping your writing in language that mimics the most difficult critics, such as Derrida, Lacan, or Spivak, all of whom are known for extremely overt and complicated use of cultural, psychoanalytic, and critical theories. Whereas their writing is very difficult to understand, the tone of an academic paper must be inviting to your readers. Remember, you are writing to a person who wants you to make your points clearly, concisely, and persuasively. Understand, too, that your readers are not impressed when you have inflated your prose, pumped up your page count, or used terms that you don't completely understand.

In short, then, good academic writing follows these rules of tone and style:

- Keep the personal in check. Some writing tasks will invite you to make a personal response to a text. For example, a professor might want you to describe your experience of a text, or to talk about personal experiences that are relevant to the topic at hand. But if you haven't been invited to make a personal response, then do not digress to write about how you feel.
- Watch your personal pronouns. Writers often wonder if it is okay to write in the first person, using "I" and "you." Different disciplines have different rules. Some allow the first person in the first chapter only, maybe in the conclusion, but many do not allow it at all. This is likely because first person point of view, "I," may make the paper seem too subjective. Likewise, using the pronoun, "you," directs your writing to a specific reader and invites the reader to read subjectively. Your task is to produce an objective analysis and proof of your argument's worth. Remember, certain academic disciplines (the sciences, for example) would frown on the use of these pronouns. When in doubt, ask your lead reader.
- Consider your use of gendered pronouns. When you write, you'll want to make sure that you don't do anything to make your readers feel excluded. If you use "he" and "him" all the time, you are excluding women as readers, or writing in a less contemporary style, but generally, and again I recommend asking your most important reader whether to use "he, him, his" or "he/she, him/her, his/hers" or to avoid this set of pronouns as much as possible. Some writers advocate always using "she" instead of "he" as a way to acknowledge a long-standing exclusion of women from texts. Whatever decision you make in the end, be sensitive to its effect on your readers. I recommend asking for guidance.

- Be aware of discipline-specific differences. Each academic discipline has its own conventions with tone and style. If you need more information about discipline-specific matters, check out a style manual, such as the MLA or APA style sheets, and check out the disciplinary guidelines for what style you should use.
- Avoid mechanical errors. No matter who your audience is, you must do your absolute best to write an error-free text. Errors in grammar and style slow your reader down and at the worst, may cause your reader to turn your paper back to you unread. Some errors obscure the meaning. Always proofread your text before passing it on to your readers.

The following tips will help you in the final stages of your project, before you hand it off to be assessed:

- Does the format follow the rules as outlined?
- Does your paper look as if it has been carefully prepared?
- Are the paragraphs clear?
- Is the line spacing appropriate?
- Do subjects and verbs agree?
- Have the appropriate verb tenses been used?
- Check for misspelled words, even if you have spell checked your work through a spell check. Print out your final copy. Read your paper in its entirety out loud to yourself, with a pen in hand, and I bet that you will find errors that your computer did not.
- Take the time to make sure all your references are correctly formatted according to the correct style manual of your field, college, or university. This includes your footnotes or endnotes, as well as your Works Cited or Bibliography pages.

The advice here is crucial because some readers will get stuck on mechanical and grammatical errors and remember only those when they read, considering your work too sloppy or disorganized, and they will not pay attention to your good ideas. Remember, you don't want anything to get in the way of holding your readers' hand as they read, and a misplaced adjective or dangling participle, or a period where there should be a comma, may cause your reader to become exasperated and stop reading. But polish at the end, not as you put your great ideas to work. Don't let anything stop you from transferring your great ideas onto the page or computer screen.

VIII. Write Clearly and Directly

Mar 14, 2011 Caroline Eisner

In previous blogs, I have stressed that advanced academic writing requires that you use strong verbs, meaningful transitions, and citation that send signals to your readers about how to make their way through your argument. This week's blog will cover a few more features of academic writing that will make your writing stronger. But to be clear, your ideas and your argument are the two most important elements of your work. Do not get hung up on "surface features"—spelling, grammar, mechanics, formatting—until you have fleshed out your ideas and argument, especially because if ideas or argument change, you will need to re-edit the surface features. Leave the surface features until everything else is finished or nearly finished.

If you edit for surface features and grammar while you are conceptualizing your ideas, you may lose your great ideas. Editing for grammar and mechanics may feel like productive work when you are stuck, but it is more than likely that you are stuck because you haven't figured out your ideas. Once you do, you may need to reorganize or rewrite your argument, and therefore need to redo the grammar and mechanics at least once before you give your section or chapter to one of your readers. If someone returns your edited manuscript with grammar and mechanic errors noted, the reader didn't really read your work for its ideas, perhaps because he or she may have become tangled in the surface features and could not get to your ideas. You want to spend dedicated time polishing your writing, but save that task for last.

However, once you are at the stage to work on surface features, be sure that you have succinctly identified and defined your topic's key terms. These terms usually imply certain assumptions— unstated beliefs about life, history, literature, or reasoning— that you haven't argued for but simply have assumed to be true. Your topic's key terms should be clear in their meaning and appear throughout (not abandoned halfway) and they should be appropriate for the subject at hand.

A distinctive feature of academic writing style is choosing the more formal word over the less formal word. Even if you hear your advisors or readers use words and phrases like stuff, things, bunch, or a whole lot of, which would be inappropriate in academic writing, or elaborate metaphors and other vivid expressions to enliven their speaking style, these are inappropriate in academic writing. Choose words that are more formal in nature and more precise. For example:

- good » considerable
- got » obtained
- a lot of » numerous
- pretty good » encouraging
- things that will happen » consequences

One of the hallmarks of academic writing is that conciseness counts. The examples above illustrate that using the more concise word is more appropriate in academic writing than the way you might say the same thing if you were speaking to a friend.

VII. Using Citations Strategically and Correctly

Mar 07, 2011 Caroline Eisner

One of the hallmarks of academic writing, as opposed to writing in The New Yorker, say, is that citations are important markers of how in-depth your knowledge of the field is and how well-grounded you are in the citation rules of the field. Through the strategic use of citations, you will:

- Acknowledge a debt of precedent to the experts who already have written about your topic or ideas.
- Display an allegiance to a particular community or orientation.
- Create a rhetorical stance for your research, and establish a credible writer ethos.

As an academic writer, you are expected to situate your ideas and research in a larger narrative. Writers usually situate their ideas with a review of the literature that has already been published.

While writing your literature review, you must also manage the tension between your own ideas and those of others. The statements you make are invariably a response to previous statements made by others. Explicit references to prior literature, through a direct quotation say, is a substantial indication of your text's dependence on contextual knowledge between writers and readers. What and how you choose to cite helps define the context of your ideas and how your ideas are a contribution to what has come before. In other words, your new work and the evidence you choose to include must be embedded in a community-generated literature to demonstrate its relevance and importance. But, you must provide the material and ideas that connect previous ideas, and your writing needs to guide the work, rather than allowing others' ideas and writing to guide your work.

Citation plays an important role in mediating the relationship between a writer's argument and his or her discourse community. Overreliance on citation to establish your own authority will not work in academic writing. It can lead to inadvertent plagiarism, or a lack of ideas on your part. Each time you include a citation, quotation, or paraphrase, ask yourself what you are trying to achieve? Without a doubt, the most important reason for writing is to allow your readers to see you as an authority on your topic and your argument. If you are a student, or new to the field, you want to show that you are moving from a student (a consumer of knowledge) to a scholar (the producer of knowledge). The wise and judicious selection of outside sources in your writing will allow your readers to view you as knowledgeable and astute on the topic, able to sift through the numerous resources and select the ones that are most important.

Finally, in a mechanical sense, "signaling citation signals" are an important element of how you deal with integrating your source material. Integral citations are those in which the name of the cited author occurs in the citing sentence, while non-integral forms make reference to the author in parenthesis or through superscript numbers. The use of one form rather than the other reflects your decision to give greater emphasis either to the reported author or to the reported message. For example, if you are talking about Einstein and E=mc2, and everyone knows Einstein said this, you might not need to mention Einstein in the sentence itself, but only in the citation. But if you want to show that you have read a famous critic, than you may want to name the critic in the sentence, such as, "When Einstein said E=mc2, the world changed." Of course, you should also cite him. The difference here is that you are, in the first case, not naming Einstein but are naming his famous equation. In the second, you are naming Einstein and the equation. But you need to ask yourself if your readers need to know it's Einstein.

In this blog entry, the main idea is that even how you use your citations and name the people whose work you refer to influences your readers' perception of your work. Too much name dropping without substance may cause readers to think you are relying on the works of others too much, and they may not believe that you actually used or understood the material you are mentioning. Not enough references to those who have come before may cause readers to doubt your knowledge of the topic. This is a tough line to walk, but as you read other articles in your field, you'll learn the ropes.

VI. Use Sources Judiciously

Feb 28, 2011 Caroline Eisner

As discussed in the last blog about the progression of your ideas and the evidence to support your ideas, work hard to use only the evidence you need to support your ideas, no more than you need and no less than you need. It should be strong and compelling, not weak and unconvincing. You will want to consider how to order the information, so that each piece of evidence builds from the one before, and as I just said, you want the information to be the most compelling evidence you can find. Don't use bits of weak information to try to make a strong point. Instead find one or two very strong points to make the argument.

As you work to develop your argument, your paper begins to look like an inverted triangle, where your review of relevant information begins broad and eventually narrows to the fine point where your readers know and understand what they need to feel as expert as you are, and therefore are able to understand and judge your argument, based on the evidence you provide and analyze.

There needs to be enough evidence to be persuasive; the right kind of evidence to support the thesis (with no obvious pieces of evidence overlooked); sufficiently concrete for the reader to trust it (e.g. in textual analysis, it often helps to find one or two key representative passages to focus on); and if summarized, summarized accurately and fairly. Use reputable and ample sources that are concrete, so that readers feel capable of judging your analysis. Don't dwell on any one source or topic for too long. A common trap is that you will feel as if you are working—by reading everything available on your topic--but you are also putting off the intellectual thinking work of writing and moving your argument forward. Likewise, your evidence needs to connect directly to your ideas, so that readers always know what inferences you are making and how the details support an idea.

Selecting and quoting relevant and important textual evidence for your argument, also requires that you:

- Show the reader why the quotation makes sense in the argument.
- Choose quotations that are relevant to the points you are making, and are quoted because something will be lost in translation if you were to paraphrase the quotation.
- Introduce and integrate quotations into the text by providing the reason for the upcoming quotation and, after the quotation, your analysis of it.
- Focus on the language of quotations in your interpretations.

Remember, if your ideas are at the center of your writing, you are integrating into your document quotations that support your argument. If you do the reverse, using your ideas to support quotations, your own ideas and voice will be lost in the voices of others, and your readers will not be able to find you in your paper.

V. Use a Logical Progression of Ideas

Feb 21, 2011 Caroline Eisner

This blog is about development of your ideas into a logical progression so that your reader can follow along with your argument. Part of becoming a good academic writer is learning to order your paragraphs and evidence in a linear progression through transitions, signal phrases, and verbs that

tell the reader if you agree or disagree with the evidence you are providing and analyzing. Each paragraph, and your paper as a whole, should follow this format:

1. Introduce the main idea that you will be discussing.
2. Provide the evidence used to prove your argument.
3. Outline the significance of the evidence you have provided.

For example, in a paragraph in which I am introducing evidence to support my ideas, I would write one or two sentences providing a transition from my last paragraph into this paragraph, and introduce the main idea of this paragraph, as well as introducing the upcoming quotation, paraphrase, or evidence. Then I would include the relevant quotation, or paraphrase. After providing the evidence, I would write an analysis (not summary) of the evidence so that the reader knows why I chose this evidence to support my argument. This may take several sentences. The point is that you shouldn't simply drop evidence into your paper and expect your reader to know make the connections. Remember, you are holding the reader's hand.

To create a smooth and logical progression of ideas, transitions need to show how the next sentences, paragraphs, and sections follow from the preceding ones, thus sustaining momentum and echoing key words or resonant phrases quoted or stated earlier. Use appropriate transitions between paragraphs or sections, so that your reader is never forced to figure out why you chose the quotation or evidence you did, or what it means. Your transitions will guide the reader from concept to concept.

When you create a logical progression of ideas, you will convince your readers by leading your reader through the most compelling ordering of your ideas. The challenge is to make your writing structure firm and clear while still allowing for complication--without making it feel mechanical or like a laundry list. Remember, no writing project is ever really finished, and new evidence may require that you restructure your argument, take a different stance, apply a different transition, etc.

This progression of ideas leads the reader to the conclusions you promise when you answer your "So What" question. Your ideas follow a logical order, and the links or transitions in that order must be apparent to the reader. These links are often referred to as the "stitching," as you stitch together your argument in a seamless yet conscientious effort to move your reader along. The argument needs to progress forward, to develop or complicate the issues, not simply to restate the main idea or what you hope to prove.

Stitching requires strong verbs and transitions, which act as signposts for the reader. These signposts indicate to the reader how a new sentence, paragraph, or section follows from the previous one.

In academic writing, you need to use strong active verbs. For example,

- Use "assist" instead of "help out."
- Use "establish" instead of "set up."
- Use "increase" instead of "going up."

Remember, writing is a process, and as your argument builds, and your ideas solidify, the ways in which you structure your argument may also change. It's all a draft until it is not.

IV. Approach the So What Question

Feb 14, 2011 Caroline Eisner

The last blog discussed the importance of developing an argument and considering the purpose, audience, and genre of your writing. In academic writing you must also address the "So What" question. The "So What" question is about giving your readers enough information so that they will want to, will feel compelled to, keep reading, rather than continually, or even once, asking themselves, "Why should I care about this?"

Will your reader care about your argument, perspective, and topic, or will your reader ask, "So what? Why should I care about this and keep reading?" Academic writing is successful when it answers the "So What" question, by providing answers to the following questions:

- What is the issue?
- What are the specific questions surrounding the issue?
- What is the context and background of the issue?
- Why does the issue matter?
- Why is it a problem?
- Why is it important to solve it?
- Where are you going to look for answers?
- Why are you going to look there?
- Why should the reader care?

Another way to think of this is to think about your motive for embarking on such an arduous intellectual writing task. What is the reason for selecting your topic? Why do you think the topic needs to be addressed and why should your readers care about your argument? Is it because (and it needs to be at least one of these):

- The truth is not what one would expect, or what it might appear to be on first reading;
- There is an interesting complexity to the topic;
- The standard opinion of this topic needs to be challenged, qualified, or righted;
- There remains a contradiction, paradox, or tension that needs to be figured out; and
- Readers can learn something interesting about a larger phenomenon by studying this smaller one.

As I said earlier, **be specific and detail-oriented**. Don't expect your readers to know what you know. You are the expert in this study. As you hold your readers' hands, remember that you need to keep them interested and to keep providing the information that will answer the "So What" question with which they began reading. As you progress through your argument, the question should disappear because you are providing new and relevant information.

III. Have a Clear Sense of Audience, Purpose, and Genre

Feb 07, 2011 Caroline Eisner

To become a good writer in your field or discipline, as Ken Hyland writes, is to pay close attention to your audience. Think about your rhetorical purpose and the academic standards of the genre in which you are writing. Are you clear about how to meet the expectations of your audience, to explain the purpose of why you are writing, and to both meet the needs of your audience and your purpose within the genre you are writing?

When thinking about your academic audience, remember that academic writing is devoted to topics and questions that are of interest to this audience. You must find a topic or a question that is relevant and appropriate to this audience. Remember that academic writing must be more than a personal response. You must write what your readers need to know to understand your topic, based on experts in the field.

Audience
Who is your **audience**? When writing an academic paper, you must not only consider what you want to say, you must also consider to whom you are saying it. In other words, it's important to determine not only what you think about a topic, but also what your audience is likely to think. What are your audience's biases and values, expectations and knowledge base? Remember, your audience is NOT you.

What do you know about your readers and their positions on your topic? What are your readers likely to know about the topic? What effect do you hope to have on your readers? Is your aim to be controversial, informative, or entertaining? Will your readers appreciate or resent your purpose?

Purpose
What is your **purpose**? If your audience knows less than you do on the topic, your first purpose is often instructional or an informative stance. If the audience knows more than you do, your first purpose is usually to display familiarity, expertise, and intelligence. Be as specific and detail oriented as possible. Don't expect your readers to know what you know. You are the expert in this study. You need to hold your readers' hands so that they can follow your argument as it progresses.

For this reason, your position on a topic does not by itself determine your rhetorical purpose because you must also consider your readers. When you decide on your rhetorical purpose, choose one that allows you to be sincere. Don't take an authoritative stance on a subject if you lack confidence in what you are writing. On the other hand, don't avoid taking a position on a subject. Nothing is worse than reading a paper in which the writer has refused to take a stance. Finally, don't write simply to please your readers. Most readers will want your argument to be engaging and to provide a fresh perspective.

Your stance on your topic depends on whether you are for or against your topic, and you build your argument through your analysis of what you research on the topic. What perspective/lens will you use to view your topic: feminist, psychoanalytic, historical, etc.? Ask yourself why you have chosen your particular perspective or stance. Does this stance reflect biases or preconceptions on your part? Is there any part of your response that might cause your readers to discount your argument as biased or un-critical? If so, you might want to reconsider your position on your topic.

Genre

What is the **genre** in which you are writing? First, it is most likely academic. If it is a dissertation, your college or university will provide you with guidelines for chapters, sections, etc. If it is an academic paper or a scholarly article, you will be working toward proving a new point, and again the genre of such a work will be made clear by your professor, or the submission guidelines of the journal. If you are unsure of what genre you need to be writing in, ask. Most academic papers require literature reviews, which adhere to their own set of guidelines, as do dissertation proposals, book or article reviews, opinion pieces, etc. Generally, all academic writing is persuasive, and requires you to perform high-level intellectual understanding of the topic through analysis (recognizing patterns suggested by facts), synthesis (producing something new from two or more sources or ideas), and evaluation (judging the quality of a solution, theory, or perspective).

II. Start with Good Ideas

Jan 31, 2011 Caroline Eisner

Before you begin writing, think about your ideas. Your ideas are the most important part of your paper, especially as your ideas begin to form themselves into an interesting, analyzable argument. Think about how you will translate your ideas into organized, well-researched, and readable prose for your intended audience. Don't worry about grammar, mechanics, and other surface features until the end, when you will show your final drafts to other readers, both at a writer center, say, and to the professors in your field and discipline. And don't forget that nothing will make a reader stop reading more quickly than poor style and grammar, even if the ideas are profound. But you don't need to worry about creating what's called "Reader-based Prose," until after you, as a writer, have conceived of your ideas and argument and decided how to order your ideas and argument so that they make the most sense to your reader.

Remember, academic writing is writing by you, a novice scholar, for more expert scholars, even if in the end you know more than they do. Of course, being a scholar requires that you read, think, argue, and write in the ways other scholars require. Your advisors and mentors will help you to understand the expectations, conventions, and requirements of scholarship in your field or discipline.

Create a focused and informed argument out of your good ideas and intended topic. Your argument needs to be true and arguable. In the early stages, however, you should think of your argument or hypothesis as changeable; as you test your argument, your ideas will become more focused. Academic writing requires analyzing (not summarizing) your focused argument by first considering your topic from all sides and then examining how these parts relate to each other or to the whole. When you analyze, you break the whole into parts so that you might see the whole in all the different ways your readers might. Some readers may agree with you, some may not. Some may need more handholding, others may know all about your topic. Think about how you want to own your ideas; and how you will leave your mark on your ideas, either by analyzing them in a new way, organizing materials in ways that make your ideas stand out, or by offering a counter argument that no one has thought of.

As you write, keep in mind that your readers need to be able to locate and understand the complexities of your argument. This means that you must be able to demonstrate your understanding of the complexities of your topic and the structure of your argument. Develop your

argument by using supporting evidence that is both formative and contemporary. Move beyond what has been said in class, by your faculty, or supervisor, to research what experts have said, and work to analyze and synthesize agreement and discrepancies between these experts.

To construct an informed argument, you must distinguish what you know about your topic from what you think about the topic. Or, to put it another way, you will want to consider what is known about your topic and then determine what you think about it. If your paper fails to inform your readers of background material they need to understand your topic and ideas, or if it fails to argue (not summarize) a legitimate point, then it will fail to meet the expectations of the academic reader. Remember, academic writing requires an argument or problem-statement, not simply a summary of what other people have said.

Strategies for Creating an Argument

Consider what you know about your topic. In general, you need to be able to "place" your argument within the larger ongoing conversation by learning or already knowing the answers to these questions:

What do I know about my topic?
Can I answer the questions who, what, when, where, why, how?
What do I know about the context of my topic?
What historical or cultural influences do I know about that might be important to my topic?
Does my topic belong to any particular genre or category of topics?
What do I know about this genre?

What seems important to me about this topic?
If I were to summarize what I know about this topic, what points would I focus on?
What points seem less important?
Why do I think so?

How does this topic relate to other things that I know?
What do I know about the topic that might help my reader to understand it in new ways?
What do I need to know more about to be able to answer questions by experts?
Why am I so interested in this topic? It must relate to other things that I know, or want to know.

What DON'T I know about my topic?
What do I need to know?
How can I find out more?

What You Think

In the process of answering these questions about your topic, you should begin to develop new observations, questions, and connections that experts on the topic have not yet raised. It's not enough to summarize in a paper what is already known and talked about. You must also add ideas of your own (what is often called the value-add). Understand, however, that "adding something of your own" is not an invitation to include your own personal associations, reactions, or experiences. To create an informed argument, you must first recognize that your writing should be analytical rather than personal. In other words, your writing must show that your associations, reactions, and experiences of a text have been framed through a critical reading of what others think, rather than through your own personal experience.

I. Becoming an Academic Writer

Jan 24, 2011 Caroline Eisner

Thanks for becoming a reader of this blog. In this series on good academic writing, the two most important ideas of this blog series are these: (1) you need to start with your own good ideas and place them at the center of all of your writing and (2) all good writing comes from a recursive process of writing, drafting, researching, citing, re-writing, re-drafting, proofing, editing, re-writing, etc. We are going to start with good ideas and end with how the writing process is recursive. You move back and forth until the day you are forced, or decide, to turn it in to your readers.
Each week, I will provide details about the following points. Stay tuned.

- Start with good ideas
- Have a clear sense of Audience, Purpose, and Genre
- Approach the "So What" question
- Use a logical progression of ideas
- Use sources judiciously
- Use citations strategically and correctly
- Write clearly and directly
- Use a consistent tone and style and make sure your writing is mechanically competent
- The writing process: From ideas to clear writing and back again

When I first became an academic writer, I made the mistake of starting with a topic (not an idea), and going to the library for hours in search of quotations on my topic, which was too broad anyway. Then I would go home with pages of quotations, poorly organized and cited, and try to string the quotations together into an idea, which wasn't mine, it was just how the quotations fit together. My ideas were nowhere, because I was too busy depending on the quotations of others to do the speaking and idea making. This absolutely had to do with my lack of belief in my own ideas, intelligence, and creativity. Gradually, thankfully, I began to grow confident in my abilities and, at some point, I realized that I could write an entire paper without any outside sources. Only when I was finished with my ideas, did I go in search of backup or counter arguments. This is the way I propose that you put your ideas at the center.

As you read this blog, you are going to hear me say this over and over again: academic writing is about communicating your own ideas. A mistake novice writers often make is to piece together other people's ideas.